

Clutter Transcript

Now let us try to understand the concept of clutter and how to address the clutter. Clutter happens when too much information or visuals or pre-attentive attributes like text, bold, colours are cramped up in a space, effectively blocking the message that the visual is trying to give. Sometimes out of enthusiasm or need we might impose certain elements like in this example you can notice the graph tries to cover top products by monthly sales and it introduced a text box trying to showcase a one particular data point which it wants to highlight.

But the entire essence of the graph is disturbed by the presence of the text box. This is what we call a typical case with clutter. The better way to present this diagram is to use the gestalt principles of foreground and principle, highlight the product that you want to showcase and use a background and use product labels and bold and different colours.

The pre-attentive attributes used strategically bring more meaning, reduce the clutter and give a deep impact to the graphic. So we have to remember whenever we are designing a graphic or a visualisation, we have to keep the audience in mind and see how their cognitive abilities are responding to the graphic. In the first case, it is cluttered, very difficult to decipher the information and the legend is also eating away the space, not providing any useful information.

In the second case, the refined graphic clearly shows the product C is performing well and product G is not performing well. So this information is readily brought out by the graphic that can be used for business decisions. Now we will understand what are the five main categories of clutter.

Rather, we will understand what are the five main sources of clutter on the graphic. For example, the first and foremost form of clutter can come from the background frame, which might not add value but can add noise. If it is very deep in colour or it has unnecessary shades, that can distort the message that you are trying to give.

Though it has nothing to do with the data, the objective background can create disturbances for people trying to perceive the information. So if needed, there must be a background, if not, it is better to keep a white space. Similarly, the graphical objects, we have to choose the graphical objects wisely to denote the problem or the information at hand.

At times, unnecessary colouring of the objects or using other creative attributes on the objects can also cause clutter. Similarly, axes are very important to read interpretation into the graphic. Now, in cases where you have to highlight only a couple of points, you can do away with axes.

Or if you have axes, clearly present them so that they are not distorting the measurement scale and unnecessarily creating complications in the visual.



Likewise, the labels. Labels are a very important tool to drive the attention of the audience.

In cases we have seen, if there is only one point that has to be mentioned, you can simply highlight that point and then add a label without giving the axes. You are directly driving attention to the person. Otherwise, your labels have to be bleeding into the graphical object so that there is continuity without breaking the cognition.

And finally, overlay of objects. These have to be used very judiciously and they have to be used in a place where it does not block the cognition of the audience. Like in the earlier example, the text box is actually helping to convey a key point, but it is badly positioned, creating clutter and increasing the cognitive load.

So, it has to be taken care how are we overlaying the objects and how are we integrating or assimilating them into the graphic. This has to be well thought and only be used judiciously. And these are the five main categories of clutter.

Addressing each one of them would improve the effectiveness of the visual.

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